economic factors – attitudes that infuriated some among the older generation of leading historians, such as Dr R. C. Majumdar, author of the monumental *History and Culture of the Indian People*, who condemned what he saw as the conscious efforts of his fellow historians to 'rewrite the whole chapter of the bigotry and intolerance of the Muslim rulers towards Hindu religion'. That argument rumbles on to this day.

In recent years there has been a conscious effort by some writers of history to highlight an aspect of Islam in India that was overlooked in the past, which is the hugely positive role in India played by the Sufi missionaries and saints, both in the North and the South. This is right and proper because it has corrected an historical imbalance. Sufism's most distinctive characteristics are its mysticism and its emphasis on ecstatic personal devotion – a devotion that overwhelmingly has been inclusive and open-hearted – and in this way it echoed and even embraced the parallel impact of Hindu bhakti. But Sufism was not always so tolerant, because it is also true to say that some of the most intolerant figures within Islam in India have been ardent Sufis or followers of Sufi saints. The Mughal emperor Aurangzeb was one such, choosing his grave so that it might be as near as possible to that of the Chisti Nizami Sufi saint Syed Zain-ud-din Shirazi.

Few Westerners visit the Heavenly City of Khuldabad these days. It lies just outside the city of Aurangabad, originally Khadke, which the young Mughal prince Aurangzeb made his headquarters when his father the Emperor Shah Jehan appointed him Viceroy of the Deccan in 1653. Aurangabad subsequently became the springboard for Aurangzeb's overthrow of his father and his many military campaigns against the Maratha highlanders of what is now Maharashtra. In Victorian times, European travellers setting out from Aurangabad for the famous rock-cut caves at Ellora would pause at Khuldabad to take in its silent,